

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*Turning Over Tables:
A Lenten Call for Disrupting Power
Reveal – Lent 1*

March 9th, 2025



*Color Study. Squares with Concentric Circles
by Wassily Kandinsky, 1913*

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Choral in A minor (César Franck)
Passacaglia in C minor (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Lenten Words of Gathering

Shalonda Martin & Rev. Fregin

Beloveds, remember this!
Though we speak in modern language,
holy truths reach from generations past.
The sacred stories we tell reveal the stuff
that lasts when everything else fades away.
They come from sources of wisdom tried and tested
through struggle and silence.

When the ones before us were tested
to their spiritual limits,
bound by oppressive restraints, made weary by loss,
these truths were a lifeline.
They reach to us still today.
They are our medicine, our strength, our memory, and our future.

No matter the risks we face in these days
as we enter this Season of Lent,
may we not sever the threads of wisdom
that weave our survival together.
We will carry on and carry out these divine teachings
that promise hope beyond our reach.

We will tell the stories of God.
We will not allow histories to become hidden -
not their ugly nor their glory.
For God is always set free through truths,
proclaimed and practiced.

Where tables exclude, we will turn them over,
and continue building a Table that welcomes and embraces all.
This lineage of liberation that companions us
through the impossible and unimaginable,
dare not end with us.

[adapt. Rev. M. Jade Kaiser, enfolded]

This is the Wisdom of our Ancestors.
Thanks be to God!

Please stand now in body or in spirit for our Lenten Hymn of Gathering

Lenten Hymn of Gathering *We Yearn, O Christ, for Wholeness

PASSION CHORALE

We yearn, O Christ, for wholeness and for your healing touch;
Too long have we felt helpless; our burdens seemed too much.
Forgetting all pretenses we make our pleadings heard,
In hope and expectation await your gracious Word.

We long to have companions who travel by our side,
Strong friends to call and answer with whom we are allied;
As we lift up each other when struggles lay us low,
Community develops; our faith and caring grow.

We need your living presence, O Christ of Galilee,
A presence that revives us and sets our spirits free.
No longer are we fearful, your love pervades each place.
Empower us with courage to claim your healing grace.

-lyrics by Dossia Carlson, Beatitudes United Church of Christ, Phoenix, Arizona

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Michael Lehman

God of our ancestors, God of our present and our future,
you are always and forever revealing fresh starts and new beginnings,
filled with possibilities for renewal and restoration;
opportunities that help us awaken to your grace,
and feel embraced by love unconditional.
With each new morning, you birth new possibilities, in us and around us.
We are surrounded by Sacred potential as we
acknowledge there are so many ways to love.

Help us in this Lenten season,
as we rise to each day's call,
to listen for the aches, to give voice to the beauty,
and to be companions to justice and peace.
Help us to be channels of your Love,
as we dare to dream and discover
its true power together.

[m.jadekaiser/adptlvf]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

"One Voice"
Cathedral Choir

RUTH MOODY

***The Lord's Prayer**

Shalonda Martin

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

From stardust and from the dust of the earth,
the Holy One breathed us into life.
Through the breath of God we are all connected.
Shaped in their image, God formed us with a purpose:
To create, to serve, to tend, to protect, to love
so that life may flourish in all its forms.
[enfleshed]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Children's Conversation

Claire Kelly

Following this conversation, children are invited to join us for our Sunday morning programming, which is held outside near the playground. If you were unable to check your children in prior to the service, please accompany them to our Children's Area and check them in before returning to the service. Children must be picked up after worship before you head to Coffee Hour in the Courtyard.

Reading from Our Religious Tradition

Shalonda Martin

from the Gospel of Mark

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Creator God,
we have been told that by your design,
we are whole people,
yet we have a hard time believing
that we are in fact made in your image –
an image that is very good.

Instead we have lived in our self imposed limits,
touching the boundaries we erect for reassurance.
We have distrusted your dream for our lives
and instead have manufactured our own nightmares.

God, forgive us.

Forgive us...
for we have been willing to be entertained
but not changed.
Forgive us...
for we have allowed our insights
to harden into clichés.
Forgive us...
for we have spoken
only to consolidate our own positions.
Forgive us...
for we have hidden behind our own privilege,
while allowing unjust realities to persist.
Forgive us...
for when we call on you,
we listen only for our own voices.
Forgive us...
for our celebrations that have left others
with nothing to enjoy.

God, forgive us.

Searching and Creative Spirit of God,
we long for you to make a community
out of the raw materials we each bring
with our lives week after week.

We ask you to reveal to us the humility
we need to learn from those
who simply and earnestly
believe that you love us,

and that you are for us,
in this journey we call life.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

“United In Song: An Anthem For Our Time”
Cathedral Choir

MARI ESABEL VALVERDE

Sermon

Reveal

Rev. Lehman

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Rev. Fregin

We gather at this expansive table,
aware of the love and grace
God so richly shares with each one of us.

We gather at this table,
aware that Jesus shares our life.
Eating with all who wonder about their worth,
Jesus welcomes all of us.

Guiding us when we lose our way,
Jesus travels with us.
Touching our lives through the service of others,
Jesus heals us.
Loving us no matter what,
Jesus receives us.

With thanksgiving we take this bread and this cup
and proclaim the life that brought love
through Jesus of Nazareth.

Prayer of Blessing

Let us pray together...
*At this table Holy One, make us one
with each other
and with all who share this feast.
Unite us in faith,
encourage us in hope,
inspire us to love,
that we may serve you
and your world.
Amen and Amen.*

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

"Kingsfold"

arr. CHARLES MAGGS

Donald Brown, Esme Gregoropoulos, Lulu Gregoropoulos, Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Handbells*

*Lenten Doxology

Praise God from whom all blessings flow.
Praise God, all creatures here below.
Praise God above ye heavenly hosts.
Creator, Christ, and Holy Ghost.

*Prayer of Offering

Shalonda Martin

Bless our gifts to the wellbeing
of this community, to all communities of good will,
and to our planet home, Steadfast Provider.

Expand our creativity, that might care for each other
collaboratively – sharing power, resources, and joy.
[Rev. Molly Bolton/adpt]

May it ever be so.

May it ever be so for all of us!

Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

The call to follow justice is easy to issue,
but the resolve to follow justice is much more difficult.
Together, let us be a community
that not only speaks of justice
but follows the path of Jesus the Christ.

*May our community be one that holds
the strength of compassion and the resolve to act.
May we be a people who unite
our words with our deeds.*

For the dignity of life and the hope of humanity,
May it be so.
May it be so for all of us and for our world!

Choral Response

"On Eagle's Wings"
Laude

MICHAEL JONCAS, arr. DAVID HARRIS

Lenten Hymn for the Journey *Praise with Joy the World's Creator

LAUDA ANIMA

Praise with joy the world's creator, God of justice, love, and peace,
Source and end of human knowledge, grace bestowing without cease.
Celebrate the Maker's glory, power to rescue and release.

Praise the Christ who feeds the hungry, frees the captive, finds the lost,
Heals the sick, upends religion, fearless both of fate and cost.
Celebrate Christ's constant presence - Friend and Stranger, Guest and Host.

Praise the Spirit sent among us, liberating truth from pride,
Forging bonds where race or gender, age or nation dare divide.
Celebrate the Spirit's treasure - foolishness none dare deride.

Praise the Maker, Christ, and Spirit, one God in Community.
Calling people to embody oneness and diversity.
Thus the world shall yet believe when shown Christ's vibrant unity.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Fugue in C minor - Reprise (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Inside The Music

"Two of our pieces this week feature women whose music carves new vistas through which we can view life. They reveal through their music, yet aren't overt about this desired justice action. Ruth Moody sings in the folk trio "The Wailin' Jennys." Their music nestles comfortably into the folk movement that has continued since it's 1960s hayday. In "One Voice," Ruth offers a simple idea. One person singing sounds a certain way. It's pleasing to hear. Add another, and the sound becomes more complex, and pleasing in new ways. Togetherness sounds enriching. Three voices brings added mystery. The more voices add, the more trust develops, and the more we can hear humanity represented in sound. The final verse says "leave the rest behind, it'll turn to dust," a fitting thought for the beginning of Lent. While reveling in the sweetness of the additive riddle, we are met with a deeper truth that people are the point of community. Likewise, Mari Esabel Valverde's "United In Song" was written as "An Anthem For Our Time." They illuminate a central question of today's human experience relating to what togetherness feels like, and how it can persist. Community, and humanity as a whole, they say, depends upon opening ourselves to the differences that each person represents. Those differences are not the end of the story, however. The chorus says "We dream of a world brave enough, proud enough to be United in song." Unity requires bravery specifically because we are uniting with people who are different from us. On its surface, Valverde's anthem might seem like a feel-good call for justice. Yet, the justice they identify isn't the kind where one person assumes vindication over another. Rather, it is the complex reality that justice requires equal representation under the tent of unity. As Valverde begins the chorus each time, they have the sopranos sing a sustained note that cuts against the building, rising lines of the rest of the ensemble. In its determined identity, this note becomes dissonance and consonance as the group moves around it. In an otherwise unison or chordal setting, this moment stands out as a brilliant image of the revelation they seek to illuminate. Each person's identity will push against the whole sometimes, and will fold into it in other ways. That continual tension and resolution represents the human experience." ~ Dr. David Harris